

QA LEADERSHIP ACADEMY

Behavioural Interview Scorecard

Assess how someone works with others against anchored criteria — with a filled example, using real evidence not gut feel.

Purpose

Most testers are not lost over technical skill — they are lost over how they collaborate, handle conflict, deal with ambiguity and respond to being wrong. This scorecard assesses those behaviours against anchored criteria, using evidence from the candidate's own examples rather than a general impression of whether they seemed "nice".

When to use it

- In a structured behavioural round, asking for real past examples (the STAR shape: situation, task, action, result).
- Whenever a role depends on collaboration — which, in a centralised QA team pulled into squads, is every role.
- To give the panel a shared language for "culture fit" that is about behaviour, not similarity to themselves.

Instructions

1. Pick the four to six behaviours the role actually needs and ask every candidate for a real example of each.
2. Probe for the candidate's specific actions — "what did you personally do?" — not what "the team" did.
3. Score each behaviour 1-4 against the anchors; capture the evidence, not just the number.
4. Distinguish culture add from culture fit: look for people who strengthen the team, not merely people who resemble it. "Fit" used loosely is where bias hides.
5. Calibrate as a panel afterwards, comparing evidence rather than gut feelings.

Scoring anchors (1-4)

Score	Meaning
1	Concerning — example reveals a red flag (blame, rigidity, no self-awareness).
2	Adequate — handled it acceptably but without much insight.
3	Strong — clear, self-aware, constructive; a good example.

Score	Meaning
4	Exceptional — handled a genuinely hard situation with maturity others could learn from.

Worked example

A filled scorecard for Candidate B (the experienced, people-strong senior tester) for Northstar's role. Northstar's environment is politically real — a sceptical payments lead, a burnt-out automation engineer, a wary informal lead — so collaboration under tension matters a great deal.

Behaviour	Score	Evidence from their example
Collaboration across teams	4	Described winning over a resistant dev team by embedding with them and shipping a shared quality gate — directly relevant to Marcus's scepticism at Northstar.
Handling conflict / disagreement	3	Gave a concrete example of disagreeing with a product manager on a release, framed as risk, reached a joint decision.
Dealing with ambiguity	3	Comfortable describing how they proceeded with unclear requirements by making assumptions explicit and checking them.
Ownership & accountability	3	Owned a released defect openly and drove the process fix, no blame-shifting.
Growth mindset / coachability	2	Answered the "time you were wrong" question but stayed a little defensive; example was fairly minor.
Mentoring / growing others	4	Rich, specific examples of levelling up junior testers — addresses the mentoring concentration risk on Sofia.
Total (max 24)	19	Exceptional on collaboration and mentoring; the softest note is coachability, worth probing at final stage.

Read: B would strengthen the team's culture and directly ease two of its people risks (dev scepticism, mentoring concentration) — which is precisely why the final decision is not a simple one, given B's weaker automation. Behavioural strength and technical fit pull in different directions here.

HR AND LEGAL NOTE

This is a decision-support tool, not legal advice. Always run your process through your own HR/People team and follow local employment law on data handling, right-to-work, records retention, reasonable adjustments and non-discrimination. Ask every candidate for a role the same questions against the same criteria, record the evidence rather than the impression, and keep your notes factual — they may be disclosable.

How to interpret the results

- A single 1 on a critical behaviour (say, blame under pressure) can outweigh a high total — behavioural red flags scale badly once someone is in the team.
- Reward candidates who can describe being wrong and what they changed; inability to do so is itself a low coachability signal.
- Beware scoring "like me" as "strong". If every high scorer resembles the existing team, you are measuring similarity, not capability.
- Read behavioural scores together with the technical rubric — the two together, weighted against your real gap, feed the final decision matrix; neither decides alone.

Blank reusable version

Behaviour	Score (1-4)	Evidence
Collaboration across teams		
Handling conflict / disagreement		
Dealing with ambiguity		
Ownership & accountability		
Growth mindset / coachability		
Mentoring / growing others		
Total		

Common mistakes

COMMON MISTAKES

Scoring likeability instead of behaviour. Accepting hypothetical answers ("I would...") instead of pressing for real past examples. Using "culture fit" as cover for hiring people who look and sound like the panel. Letting one glowing story halo the whole score. Failing to probe how someone handled being wrong. Skipping panel calibration, so each interviewer quietly applies a different bar.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

Hire for culture add, not culture fit. The question is not "would they blend in?" but "what does this person make the team capable of that it is not capable of today?" A team of six people who all think alike has a bus factor problem of a different kind.